Workbook 3: The Value Dimension

Class2Career: Creating and Communicating Value
By Ignis Spindler

Introduction: What Is Value?

In business, "value" is one of the most-used and least-defined words. Everyone talks about value. But nobody can point to it.

That's because value is contextual. It's subjective. It's situational.

Value is what someone is willing to pay for.

In this workbook, you'll learn: 1. **What value actually means** — beyond the buzzword 2. **How to create value** — in your work, your products, your interactions 3. **How to communicate value** — so others recognize what you bring

By the end, you'll understand how to create measurable value in any business context — and how to make sure people notice.

Part 1: The Nature of Value

It's Not What You Think

Value isn't a feature. It isn't a benefit. It's the outcome someone gets from using your product, service, or expertise.

Your instructor puts it this way: "You know when you have value. But you can't always point to it. When you buy water, there's water that tastes like plastic — and there's water that tastes fresh. Same product. Different value."

The Value Equation

Value = Outcome Received ÷ Cost to Obtain

- **Higher outcome** = more value
- **Lower cost** = more value

Businesses constantly optimize this equation. If your product delivers better outcomes at lower cost, you have competitive advantage.

Types of Value

Functional Value — Does it solve a problem? - A spreadsheet that calculates costs - A tool that automates a manual process - A faster algorithm - A better process that reduces errors

Emotional Value — How does it make people feel? - Pride of ownership - Confidence in decisions - Reduced anxiety - Peace of mind

Economic Value — What's the financial impact? - Time saved × hourly rate - Revenue generated - Cost avoided - Risk reduced

Social Value — What does it say about the user? - Status - Belonging - Identity - Reputation

The best products and services deliver on multiple levels. A luxury car isn't just transportation (functional) — it's status (social) and confidence (emotional) wrapped in a financial decision.

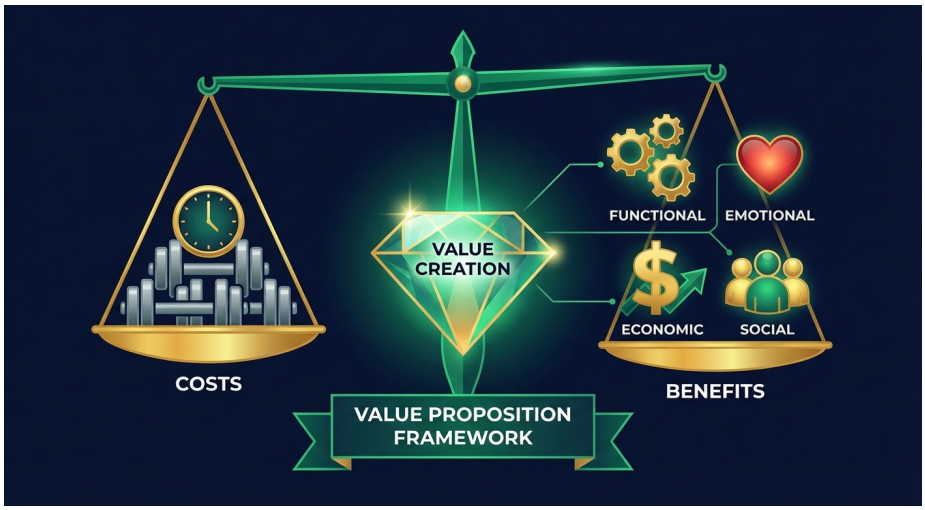

Figure 1: Value Framework

Value in Relationships

Here's something they don't teach in school: **relationships have value too.**

Your instructor: "There are relationships I have where I know it's a valuable relationship. I'm not going to put a dollar amount on it. But I get value from it."

In business, relationships are currency. Your network determines your opportunities. The more value you provide to others (without keeping score), the more likely others will help you when you need it.

This is why networking matters — but not the slimy kind. **Genuine relationships** create long-term value for everyone involved.

Part 2: Adding Value to a Business

The Core Insight

Your instructor emphasizes: "Every business person says they want to 'add value.' But few can define what that means."

Here's how to actually add value:

1. **Be a customer of your own business** — Use your product. Experience what customers experience. You'll find bugs, friction, and opportunities others miss.
2. **Submit high-quality work** — This sounds obvious. But in business, "high-quality" means:
   - Graphs with labels
   - Spreadsheets with formulas pre-entered
   - Emails with extra detail
   - Deliverables that are "plug and play"
3. **Make unique contributions** — If it's easy to replicate, it's not valuable. Bring skills or perspectives others don't have.
4. **Encourage faster production** — Speed is a feature. If you can do in 5 hours what used to take 10, you've added value.
5. **Improve processes** — Identify bottlenecks. Automate repetitive tasks. Document what works.
6. **Ask the right questions** — Sometimes the most valuable thing you do is surface a problem no one else saw.

Your instructor's example: "I built an NLP model that counts catheter infections in hospitals. Nurses were doing this manually — walking room to room, jotting down numbers. My model saves 10+ hours per ward per week. At $50/hour, that's $500/week per ward. That's value."

Part 3: Quantifying Value

Why Numbers Matter

In business, what gets measured gets managed. But value isn't always easy to measure.

Your instructor admits: "In data science, I know I add value. But proving it in dollars? That's hard."

Here's how to try:

The Baseline Method: 1. Measure the current state (time, cost, error rate) 2. Implement your solution 3. Measure the new state 4. Calculate the difference

Example: - Before: Nurses spend 10 hours/week manually tracking infections - After: NLP model does it automatically - Value: 10 hours × $50/hour × 52 weeks = $26,000/year per ward

The Proxy Method: If you can't measure directly, find a proxy: - Customer satisfaction scores (NPS) - Time to resolution - Error rates - Employee utilization

The Revenue Connection: The strongest value propositions tie to revenue: - Does your work help the company make more money? - Does your work help the company save money? - Can you express it in dollars?

Part 4: Productivity and Value

The Productivity Paradox

"Productivity" is one of the squishiest words in business. Everyone wants it. Few can define it.

Your instructor: "In revenue, measurement is easy — dollars are clear. But for most employees, productivity is ambiguous."

Key Productivity Metrics

For Individuals: - Tasks completed vs. planned (completion rate) - Focus hours per day - Time to deliverable

For Teams: - Velocity (stories completed per sprint) - Defect escape ratio (bugs released to production) - Ticket resolution time

For the Business: - Revenue per employee - Customer satisfaction (NPS) - Employee utilization rate

Frameworks for Productivity

Agile — Deliver value in small increments. Roll out the most important feature first, then iterate. "Don't spend a week building a spreadsheet. Deliver one useful number on Day 1."

Lean — Eliminate bottlenecks. Focus on what adds value, cut what doesn't. Toyota's famous for this.

Six Sigma — Reduce defects. Aim for near-perfect quality. Used in manufacturing and process-heavy industries.

The Key Insight

Your instructor: "Productivity is just process improvement. If you see something happening inefficiently, make it better. Make it work, then make it better,

then make it fast."

Part 5: Communication and Accountability

Value Requires Visibility

Here's a brutal truth: **If no one knows what you did, it didn't happen.**

Your instructor advises: "Keep a log of every project you complete. When raise discussions come, you'll forget what you've done. The business forgets faster."

The Meeting Framework

Every meeting should end with: 1. **Accountability** — "Here's what I'll do: [X] by [date]" 2. **Timeline** — "I'll have this done by Tuesday" 3. **Follow-up** — "Let's meet Monday to review results"

Your instructor: "If 4 people meet for an hour, at $100/hour each, that's a $400 meeting. Everyone should leave knowing what they're doing next."

The Follow-Up Habit

- Send a follow-up email after every meeting
- When you expect a response and don't get one, follow up
- Never add snarky tone — just: "Following up!"
- Make it easy for people to say yes

State Your Goals

In interviews and performance reviews, speak in terms of measurable outcomes:

- "I delivered X, which resulted in Y"
- "I reduced processing time by Z%"
- "I increased team productivity by A%"

Part 6: Your Path — The Three Tracks

Track A: Undergraduate / Early Career

Your challenge: You haven't yet proven you can create business value.

Your focus: - Learn to measure your inputs - Find quick wins - Ask for feedback

Your assignment: 1. For one task you do regularly, calculate how much time it takes 2. Identify one way to do it faster 3. Track your completion rate for a week

Track B: Master's / Mid-Level Transition

Your challenge: You have skills but haven't connected them to business outcomes.

Your focus: - Quantify your impact - Connect to revenue - Communicate value

Your assignment: 1. For a past project, calculate its value in dollars 2. Write a one-sentence value statement: "I did X, which saved/generated $Y" 3. Practice: Explain your work in terms of outcomes, not process

Track C: PhD / Senior Professional Pivot

Your challenge: Deep expertise. Risk of over-explaining.

Your focus: - Simplify your message - Lead with impact - Be a translator

Your assignment: 1. Write a 30-second pitch that skips your credentials 2. Identify one business problem only you can solve 3. Practice: "Here's what I can do for you" vs. "Here's what I know"

Part 7: Public Sector Transition

Coming from government or non-profit? Here's how value translates:

Public Sector	Private Sector
Mission accomplished	Value delivered
Budget spent wisely	ROI generated
Stakeholder satisfaction	Customer delight
Compliance	Efficiency

What Transfers

- Problem identification
- Solution design
- Stakeholder management
- Documentation

What You Need to Learn

- Outcome orientation
- Speed and iteration
- Revenue connection
- Quantification

Workbook Exercises

Exercise 1: The Value Audit

For your last project (academic or professional): - What problem did it solve? - Who benefited? - How would you measure the benefit in dollars?

Exercise 2: The Baseline

Choose one process you interact with regularly: - What's the current time/cost? - What's one improvement you could make? - What's the new time/cost?

Exercise 3: The Meeting Test

In your next meeting, practice: - State your goal at the start - End with specific accountability - Send a follow-up summary

Exercise 4: The Value Story

Write a one-paragraph story about a time you added value. Include: - The problem - Your action - The measurable outcome

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Book Recommendations

1. **The Mom Test** by Rob Fitzpatrick — How to ask the right questions and get honest feedback. Essential for understanding value from the customer's perspective.
2. **The Five Dysfunctions of a Team** by Patrick Lencioni — Classic on building trust and teamwork. Foundation for creating value together.
3. **Coaching for Performance** by John Whitmore — The coaching mindset. How to unlock potential in yourself and others.
4. **Mindset: The New Psychology of Success** by Carol Dweck — Growth mindset vs. fixed mindset. Essential for continuous improvement.
5. **Getting Things Done** by David Allen — The classic productivity system. How to capture, clarify, and complete work.
6. **The Lean Startup** by Eric Ries — Build-measure-learn. How to create value through iteration.

Reflection Questions

1. What does "value" mean to you? How has that definition evolved?

2. Which type of value (functional, emotional, economic, social) do you create most naturally?
3. How do you currently measure your own productivity?
4. What's one way you could quantify your impact more clearly?

Next Workbook: The Product Dimension — Building and delivering what customers want.

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